

"AND LET US CONSIDER HOW WE MAY SPUR ONE ANOTHER ON TOWARD LOVE AND GOOD DEEDS, NOT GIVING UP MEETING TOGETHER."—**HEBREWS 10:24–25**

GROUP LEADERS

Group Leader Handbook · Southeast Students

2026–2027

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WELCOME, NEW LEADER

LET'S GET TO WORK

We're so glad you're here. Stepping into student ministry matters now more than ever. This is not about showing up once a week—you're joining a movement of what God is doing to change lives for eternity.

143,556 students are without Christ in our region. They don't know Jesus—but change starts one student at a time—and God wants to use you.

Every game, every question, every text, every time you show up—it matters. Students need consistent voices who love them, listen, speak truth, and point them to Jesus. You may become one of the most spiritually influential people in their lives.

You're not just a volunteer; you're a shepherd—and you're not doing it alone. You're part of a team that will equip, support, and pray with you.

Will you lead with urgency, love, and courage this year? We believe God will use you in powerful ways.

GRATEFUL,
YOUR STUDENT MINISTRY TEAM

01

SECTION 01

MISSION + MANTRAS

The GPS that keeps every ministry effort on course.

WHO WE ARE

As members of the body of Christ, we seek Great Commission and Great Commandment living **(Matt. 22:37–40 · Matt. 28:18–20).**

As members of this local body of Christ called Southeast, we seek to live this way through connecting people to Jesus and one another, utilizing some metaphors based on the life of Christ to keep us focused.

You, as a Group Leader in Student Ministry, are a culture carrier of our Mission and Mantras. You should frequently use them as a GPS to keep our ministry efforts focused on accomplishing Great Commission and Great Commandment living.

WHO WE ARE

MISSION + MANTRAS

MISSION

CONNECTING

PEOPLE

TO JESUS

AND

ONE ANOTHER

VISION

TO UNLEASH

THE FULL FORCE

OF THE CHURCH

TO LOVE PEOPLE

ONE AT A TIME

METAPHORS FROM THE LIFE OF CHRIST

BE THE BRANCH (JOHN 15:1–17)

We connect in community.
We value connection *to* Jesus over production *for* Jesus.

CATCH THE WIND (JOHN 3:1–8)

We connect the full force of the church with the Holy Spirit.
We value risk and adventure over safety and comfort.

WRECK THE ROOF (LUKE 5:18–25)

We will radically love people one at a time.
We value innovation over tradition.

GRIP THE PLOW (LUKE 9:57–62)

We serve with intentional and focused effort.
We value personal engagement over attendance.

EMPTY THE JAR (LUKE 7:36–50)

We connect through sacrificial generosity.
We value expressive worship over religious rituals.

FOUR QUESTIONS

Connecting students to Jesus and one another starts with four questions for every leader:

01 **How am I connecting to Jesus?**

Your connection to Christ matters more than what you offer in service to Christ. God's Word and prayer are the fuel for an effective ministry.

02 **How am I connecting to one another?**

Being connected to Jesus isn't enough. Jesus modeled community through the Trinity, but also through the disciples he walked with. Remember, ministry is a team effort.

03 **How am I connecting people to Jesus?**

As we are transformed, our purpose shifts. Jesus understood His mission—to seek and save the lost. He left the mission in the disciples' hands. That mission is now yours to carry.

04 **How am I connecting people to one another?**

Neighborhoods, schools, workplaces and families need you to have vision for cultivating community. Belonging often opens the door of reception to Christ.

NOW & NEXT VALUES

It's easy to focus on what's happening in a student's life *now* and forget to prepare them for what's *next*. These five values shape how we lead—and what we ask of you.

01 **Be equipped**

You're not on your own. We'll equip and empower you to shepherd students through training, huddles, and a team leader in your corner. **Ephesians 4:12**

02 **Partner with parents**

Parents are the biggest influence in a student's faith. Learn their names, keep them in the loop, and work with them, not around them.

03 **Reach the lost**

Help your students see their friends the way Jesus does—and give them the courage to invite and share.

04 **Next steps**

Help every student take their next step with Jesus and in life: baptism, a group, a serving role, a mission trip.

05 **Intergenerational**

Students grow when adults of every age know them. Connect them to the wider church to serve, worship, and learn alongside other generations.

02

SECTION 02

YOUR ROLE

What we ask of you—and what a win looks like.

ROLE OVERVIEW

STAFF

- Shepherding Team Leaders
- Keeping the whole ministry on mission
- Being examples to the flock **1 Peter 5:2–4**
- Equipping Team Leaders

TEAM LEADER

- Shepherding a team of leaders
- Keeping your team focused on the mission
- Setting the pace for your teams
- Leading by example for your team **1 Cor. 11:1**

LEADER

- Shepherding students
- Initiating investment in a few
- Living out your spiritual gifts in the context of your team and the ministry in which you serve

SUPPORT LEADER

- Plugging new and unconnected students in
- Supporting ministry efforts
- Engaging students and families

IF JESUS LED A SMALL GROUP

LUKE 9 RHYTHMS

Five rhythms for leader culture, based on the Luke 9 ministry team—and where you live them as a Group Leader.

COMMUNITY

"Jesus called the twelve together..."

Luke 9:1a

- **SMALL GROUP**
- **HUDDLES**
- **HANGOUTS**

EQUIPPING

"He gave them power and authority..."

Luke 9:1b

- **UNLEASHED LEADERS**
- **BIG 3**
- **TRAININGS**

MISSION

"He sent them out..."

Luke 9:2

- **YOUR +1**
- **SCHOOL ENGAGEMENT**

CARE

"They all ate and were satisfied..."

Luke 9:17

- **YOUR TEAM LEADER**
- **FOLLOW-UP**

RETREAT

"Jesus was praying in private and his disciples were with him..."

Luke 9:18

- **CAMPS & RETREATS**
- **CELEBRATIONS**

3 WINS FOR STUDENT GROUPS

THREE WINS

"HIGH ACCOUNTABILITY, LOW CONTROL"

01 **Connect to Jesus**

Did your students open the Bible? It would be a mistake to gather with students and never open God's living and active Word. Make this the priority.

02 **Connect to one another**

Did your students connect? Watch for the one sitting off to the side on their phone, and help the group pull them back in. Students just want simple relational connection.

03 **One at a time**

One meal, one conversation, one need, one prayer. Keep a listening ear open—listen for ways you can follow up during the week.

SMALL GROUP LEADER EXPECTATIONS

WHAT WE ASK OF YOU

Five expectations, one for each of our mantras—the pictures from the life of Christ that shape how we lead.



BE THE BRANCH John 15:1–17

We connect in community. We value connection *to* Jesus over production *for* Jesus.

- Attend a weekend service.
- Be in a group of your own—Bible study, small group, etc.
- Have, or be seeking, a personal mentor.
- Be growing in your personal study and prayer disciplines.



CATCH THE WIND John 3:1–8

We connect the full force of the church with the Holy Spirit. We value risk and adventure over safety and comfort.

- **Build the boat well.** Come prepared: 30 minutes in the week's passage, writing questions, and praying for your group.
- **Work with the wind.** Ask questions. Talk no more than 20% of group time.
- **Know your crew.** Know how to push each student, when to give them their moment, and when to redirect.

THE BASICS

Co-leaders + teams
Every group has at least one co-leader, on a larger team in your grade and ministry.

On time
30 minutes before service, every week.

August to July
Students thrive on consistency. Your co-leader covers you for sickness or travel.



WRECK THE ROOF Luke 5:18–25

We will radically love people one at a time. We value innovation over tradition.

- Create new ways to connect with your group—hang-outs, bringing things to group.
- Lead your group to invite friends. Plan how you will celebrate a new student, and create a group identity.
- Know where each student is spiritually. Anyone not baptized? Anyone struggling with faith?
- **Have a Timothy.** When asked, be able to say their name. Do for one what you wish you could do for everyone.



GRIP THE PLOW Luke 9:57–62

We serve with intentional and focused effort. We value personal engagement over attendance.

- Serve with HSM or MSM every week, including the leader meeting.
- Have one touchpoint with a student outside of service each week—a text, a shared scripture, coffee, a game or recital.



EMPTY THE JAR Luke 7:36–50

We connect through sacrificial generosity. We value expressive worship over religious rituals.

- **Go to the big events:** Camp (HSC / MSC), Experience WKND (MSM overnight), Fall Retreat (HSM overnight).
- **Own a +1.** Step up and own one more responsibility: communion prep, set-up and tear-down, hosting, teaching, tech, contacting first-time guests.

03

SECTION 03

BIG THREE

MSM + HSM. Three times a year we gather all our Student Ministry leaders together.

ALL LEADERS · THREE TIMES A YEAR

THE BIG THREE

These are high priority events for our ministry. We expect you to be fully present.

The Big Three are also a pivotal part of our onboarding process for new leaders. Connected to each one, we host an **Unleashed Leader Training** for all new and potential leaders to on-ramp into our ministry—with flexibility for onboarding when we aren't near one of those planned starting points.

Your participation at each of these keystone moments is vital. We believe these moments together as a Student Ministry are foundational to keeping us aligned. **Put these dates on your calendar every year—and bring someone with you!**

THE BIG THREE

EVENTS + TIPS

AUGUST
Leader Launch

Vision cast + launch into the new school year.

TIP

Lock in the date before summer. Know someone who'd make a great leader? Invite them to serve at camp—camp is the best on-ramp into the fall.

JANUARY
Leader Night

Reset + halftime speech for second semester.

TIP

Save the date in August, before the semester fills up. It's the reset you'll want for spring.

MAY
Leader Celebration

Celebrate all that God has done.

TIP

Save the date in January. Bring someone who's thinking about serving—it's a great first look at our team before camp.

PRECEDING EACH OF THE BIG THREE

UNLEASHED LEADERS (ALL YEAR)

Unleashed Leaders is a deep dive into our "why"—a training we expect every new leader to go through.

It sets up new leaders to learn who we are as a Student Ministry. Whether someone joins to lead a group or serve at check-in, they need to know our primary aim is to make disciples. We look at the life of Christ and allow it to inform how we approach ministry.

Since Jesus himself continually raised the bar for his disciples, we inform those joining us about the cost of following Jesus up front, so later they aren't surprised by what we ask of them. In some ways it can appear we are talking people out of doing ministry. In actuality, we are just echoing Jesus' call to make disciples—even some who heard it straight from Jesus' mouth chose not to follow.

We know things happen—but being up front about the commitment pays dividends when leaders know what they are signing up for and stick it out. Know someone who should serve with us? **Unleashed Leaders is their front door**—invite them and point them to the next one. **We love the community of leaders God has blessed us with. We get to fulfill Jesus' mission together!**

04

SECTION 04

LEADING WELL IN GROUPS

Practical skills for every group night—before, during, and when it gets hard.

BEFORE GROUP STARTS

Most group problems are solved before group starts.

01 **Sit with your students**

During large group, spread out through the room, not along the back wall. It protects the environment, builds shared memories, and keeps you close when a student needs you.

02 **Split up the leaders**

Sit across the circle from your co-leader. You'll engage the whole group and cut down on side conversations.

03 **Set group guidelines**

Let students help write them, then come back to them all semester. Start with these:

- Respect one another
- Stay with the group the whole time
- What's shared here stays here
- Don't interrupt
- Put away distractions (like phones)

5 KEYS



Create an environment for discussion

Sit in a circle, on the same level. Everyone can see each other—and everyone feels free to share.



Turn statements into questions

Facilitate, don't teach. Use more question marks than periods, and skip yes-or-no questions.



Involve every student

Don't fill the silence with your own answer. Ask "What do you think?" and give it room—a little awkward silence never hurt anybody.



Don't read off the curriculum

Know the topic ahead of time and ask in your own words. The less you look down, the more it feels like a conversation.



Follow up during the week

Students need someone to walk with them, not talk at them. See **Follow Up** for how—page 29.

WHEN A GROUP STALLS

GETTING UNSTUCK

01

Get easy wins

Blank stares usually mean the question was too hard. Ask simpler questions to build confidence, then work toward tougher ones.

02

Get fun

The first part of group is for fun, so students grow as a family. Use that time to earn the right to challenge them.

03

Get out

Experiences beyond Sunday—serving and showing up during the week—directly fuel your group time.

04

Get better questions

A great question yields as much as a great answer. Practice them before group; write a few of your own.

05

Get visual

A big sticky pad and a few markers pull everyone in. Drawing or writing answers makes the lesson stick.

PRAYER IN GROUPS

Your group may be the only place a student is prayed for all week.

01 **Ask for requests**

"How can I pray for you?" Then go further: what are you thankful for? Where have you seen God move?

02 **Write them down**

What students share matters. It's okay to pull out paper—it helps you keep praying all week.

03 **Set time aside**

Don't save prayer for the last minute. Rushed prayer tells students it isn't important.

04 **Let students pray**

Ask who wants to pray for the group. If no one volunteers, happily take it yourself.

05 **Tell them you're praying**

Remind students you pray for them during the week, and check in on the hard ones.

STUDENT BEHAVIOR

The goal is to keep every student in the room. Start with your group guidelines (page 22). When behavior keeps getting in the way, follow three strikes.

01
STRIKE 1

Both leaders talk with the student

Have an intentional conversation: "We're so glad you're here, and when you're here, you can't _____." Name the specific behavior with examples, and make sure the student understands.

02
STRIKE 2

Bring in your team leader

A second conversation addresses the issue with the next level of leadership.

03
STRIKE 3

Bring in staff

The student is told that if the issue isn't corrected, staff will call a meeting with their parents or guardians.

> Every campus has different layers of leadership. If your campus doesn't have a team leader in place, go to staff at Strike 2. A safety concern is never a strike—bring in staff right away (page 40).

SECTION 05

SHEPHERDING STUDENTS BEYOND GROUPS

Care and discipleship outside of group night—earning trust, following up, and helping students grow.

SHEPHERDING STUDENTS

EARNING TRUST

Students open up to leaders they trust. Five ways to earn it:

01 **Learn their name**

A name is the sweetest sound to a student. Learning it says they're known, loved, and important.

02 **Be consistent**

When students can count on you being there, they learn they can count on you.

03 **Show up when you don't have to**

Games, recitals, events. Time outside of programming builds the relationship in a more carefree setting.

04 **Jump into teachable moments**

Everyday moments open doors to talk about Jesus. Step through them.

05 **Speak truth in love**

Hard truths land best in a loving, non-threatening space. **Ephesians 4:15**

SHEPHERDING STUDENTS

FOLLOW UP

Shepherding students well means listening well in group—and following up after it.

01 **Listen for the follow-up**

A test, a tryout, a hard week at home. When a student shares it in group, that's your next conversation.

02 **Ask the next question**

"How did it go?" opens the door. "What was the hardest part?" keeps it open.

03 **Check in during the week**

A text, a card, a quick call. Keep group texts plural and include your co-leader—see Digital Guardrails, page 42.

04 **Close the loop**

If something is heavy, ask for updates and let them know you're still praying. If it's a yellow or red light, bring in staff—page 40.

USING YOUR TIME

Your role takes about two hours a week at church. Whether you have 15 extra minutes or four extra hours, you can make a real investment in students.

15 MINUTES

- Pray for your group by name
- Write a card to a student
- Send your group an encouraging text

1 HOUR

- Go to a student's game, recital, or event
- Have lunch with a parent
- Start a reading plan with your group

2 HOURS

- Throw a small group party or hang-out
- Plan a service project for your group
- Show up for the big moments—a funeral, a graduation

4 HOURS

- Volunteer at a school
- Take an extra training—a book or a podcast
- Serve alongside student staff

MEET STUDENTS WHERE THEY ARE

WHAT STUDENTS NEED

Every student has a need. Four chairs helps us pinpoint that need. As a leader, consider the following questions and see if God might reveal how you could meet the needs of the students around you.



CHAIR 1

THE LOST

"Come and See" John 1:35–39

NEEDS Christ-followers in their lives who are willing to enter into their world relationally.

QUESTIONS Who has God placed right around you? Are you entering into their world? Would people identify you as a "friend of sinners," as Jesus was? Are you willing to leave the comfort of your home or church to enter into the world of those without Christ?



CHAIR 2

THE BELIEVER

"Follow Me" John 1:43

NEEDS Christ-followers giving them personalized attention to the basics of the Christian life.

QUESTIONS Do they know God's story? Can they articulate their own story and how it fits into God's story? Do they know how to confess sin, claim God's forgiveness and walk in the power of the Holy Spirit? Are they learning to feed themselves?



CHAIR 3

THE WORKER

"Follow Me & I Will Make You Fishers of Men" Matthew 4:19

NEEDS Christ-followers calling them to action and to experience God using them.

QUESTIONS Are they faithful, available, teachable, enthusiastic about the things of God, and responsive to leadership? Are they ministering in the Spirit? Are they living out their spiritual gifts? Are they willingly bearing their cross daily?



CHAIR 4

DISCIPLE-MAKER

"Go and Bear Fruit" John 15:15–16

NEEDS To be a Christ-follower who is making disciple-making disciples.

QUESTIONS Have they successfully discipled someone into a disciple-maker? Are they secure in their walk with the Lord? Have they committed all of their life to fulfilling Jesus' Great Commission?

I WANT TO FOLLOW CHRIST

Five things a new believer needs to grow before becoming a worker—ask how Jesus shaped each in His disciples.

I — **Identity—who am I in Christ?**

Help new believers see their new identity—otherwise, letting the old self die feels like losing something precious instead of gaining it.

W — **Walk—how do I follow Christ?**

"Walk as Jesus walked" (1 John 2:6). Learn His character, His priorities, and His habits.

T — **Talk—what is the good news?**

Grow in gospel fluency and urgency—God's story, and how their story fits inside it.

F — **Feed—how do I feed myself?**

Make daily time with God a priority: prayer, worship, reading, journaling, or walking in His creation.

C — **Clean—what do I do when I sin?**

Walk students through daily repentance, confession, and a renewed commitment when sin creeps back in.

06

SECTION 06

DECISION GUIDE

Helping a student take their next step toward Jesus—and what to say in the moment.

THE BRIDGE

1 US + GOD

Genesis 1 describes the start of everything, including the start of humanity. God made us and began a relationship with us.

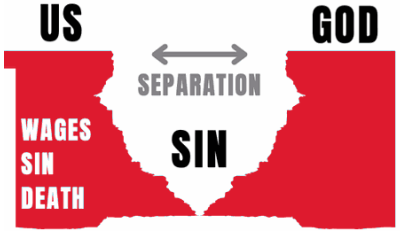
2

Genesis 3 describes how our relationship with God was broken by humanity's disobedience.

We call this disobedience "sin." God can have nothing to do with sin. Read **Romans 3:23**.



3

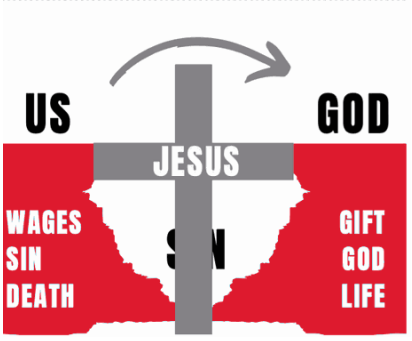


Romans 6:23 and **Isaiah 59:2** describe the problem sin creates and its consequences. Sin separates us from God and causes death. There is nothing we can do to return to God on our own.

4

Romans 5:8, **Romans 10:9–10** and **Acts 2:38** tell us about the solution. His name is Jesus.

Jesus died for everyone's sin, conquered death, and made a way for us to be with God again. When we trust in Jesus and choose to be baptized, we are saved!



BAPTISM



Purpose: to help a student reflect on their *decision* for Christ and the *commitment* of baptism.

1. STARTING QUESTIONS

- Tell me about your journey with Jesus so far.
- Why do you want to get baptized?
- Share with me your understanding of the gospel.
- Do you have any questions or things you're unsure about?

2. GOSPEL CONVERSATION *(SEE THE BRIDGE, PAGE 36)*

Genesis 1	God created us for relationship
Genesis 3	Sin breaks that relationship
Isaiah 59:2	Sin leads to separation from God
Romans 6:23	We deserve death, but God gifts us new life
Romans 5:8	Christ made a way back for us to God
Acts 2:38	Confession leads to forgiveness of sins

ROMANS 6:4

"We were therefore buried with him through baptism into death in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father, we too may live a new life."

3. WHAT IS BAPTISM?

- Ask the student to read **Romans 6:1–7** aloud.
- Baptism is a symbol:

Dying to our **old life** *under the water*	Rising to **new life** in Jesus *coming up*

- Baptism doesn't save us. It is our response to what Jesus already did.

4. NOW WHAT?

- Read **2 Corinthians 5:17 to 6:2**.
- Today is the day of salvation! Will you go now and be Christ's ambassador? He wants to use you to reach others! Who will you tell?

07

SECTION 07

SAFETY & CARE

Keeping students and leaders safe—in person, online, and in tough conversations.

CONVERSATIONS GUIDE



SE Students wants every leader to promote safety and awareness in tough conversations. Ministry is messy and these topics can feel intimidating—here are the **guidelines for how to best proceed**.

GREEN LIGHT

"Green means go."

You've got this. You have both the Sword and the Spirit.

- Family problems
- Relational problems
- Homesickness
- Heartfelt confessions
- Questions about dating & sex
- Church & theological questions

YELLOW LIGHT

"Proceed with caution."

Mention it to a staff member for coaching.

- Bullying
- Pornography
- Eating disorders
- Drugs or alcohol
- Anxiety or depression
- Engagement in sexual activity
- Gender & sexual identity questions

RED LIGHT

"Stop and get help."

Get a staff member and bring them into the conversation.

- Self-injury
- Hearing voices / hallucinations
- Sexual & physical abuse reported
- Suicidal / homicidal thoughts (threats to harm)

STUDENT TO LEADER: IN PERSON

Southeast takes seriously the responsibility of keeping our people safe. Here are some best practices when interacting with students in person.

PROGRAMMING

- **Keep students in programming.** We want all students in the student room. If a student wants to talk one-on-one, wait until after program and groups end, and meet in a public area where you are visible to others.
- **Appropriate interactions.** Appropriate touches with a student: handshakes, high-fives, and side hugs.
- **When a student's ride is late.** Never leave a student waiting alone—wait with two adults. If you have a parent or guardian's permission to drive a student home, bring another cleared adult.

COUNSELING

- **Counsel same gender.** If a student of the opposite gender comes to you for counsel, connect them with a leader of the same gender.
- **Be visible.** Meet in a public area where you are visible to other people. Never meet in private.
- **Review the Counseling Spotlight.** When counseling a student, refer to the **Stoplight Guide** on how to best proceed in conversation.

OUTSIDE OF CHURCH

- **Pair up with another leader.** When planning an outside activity with students, always include another cleared adult and stay within the 1:25 student/leader ratio.
- **Transporting students.** Never give a student a ride home unless you have another cleared leader in the vehicle and a parent's or guardian's approval.
- **Communicating digitally.** When texting or using social media with students, follow the **Digital Communication Safety Guardrails** on the next page.

STUDENT TO LEADER: ONLINE

When it comes to digital interactions, the following are some best practices to promote safety and create a healthy environment between leaders and students.

TALK TO PARENTS FIRST

Make parents and guardians fully aware of all the digital methods that will be used to communicate with students for ministry purposes.

KEEP IT PLURAL

Want to let an absent student know they were missed, or tell someone you're proud of them? Use plural pronouns instead of singular ones. Rather than "I missed you," say "We missed you."

ADD A CO-LEADER

Adding another leader helps with accountability. Group texting is the preference for all digital communication. At no time should one-on-one video communication take place between a student and leader.

COMMUNICATION LIMITS

Most conversations can wait until the next day—a healthy boundary. Use "scheduled sending" for messages composed outside acceptable hours (e.g. write a message at 9:30 p.m. and schedule it to go out at 7:00 a.m. the next day).

TRACEABLE COMMUNICATION

Apps with a "self-destruct mode" can create dangers when adults use them to communicate with minors. To be above reproach, only communicate with students in ways that are traceable. Never delete a conversation with a student.

COMING SOON

GROUP TOOLS

How-tos for the tools you'll use every week.

PLACEHOLDER

Group Manager · attendance tracking · roster and parent contacts.

Content to be added.

SPACE TO THINK

NOTES

SPACE TO THINK

NOTES

SPACE TO THINK

NOTES


Southeast
Students
CONNECTING PEOPLE TO JESUS & ONE ANOTHER